WEEK 8: RELAPSE PREVENTION - PART 1 & PHASE 1 REVIEW

Lapse vs. Relapse

Before we go further, let's define these terms clearly. Many men use them interchangeably, but there's an important difference.

LAPSE: A Slip or Mistake

What it is:

- A single instance of returning to old behavior
- A momentary loss of control
- One decision that didn't align with your values

What it's NOT:

- The end of your recovery
- Proof that you've failed
- A reason to give up

Example: You looked at pornography for 20 minutes after 3 weeks of progress.

How to respond:

- Stop the behavior as soon as you recognize it
- Use this as learning: What triggered it? What can I do differently?
- Get back on track immediately
- Don't let shame drive you into more behavior

RELAPSE: Return to Old Pattern

What it is:

- A return to the full cycle of compulsive behavior
- Multiple instances of acting out

- Abandoning recovery efforts
- Going back to pre-treatment patterns

What it's NOT:

- Inevitable
- Permanent
- A sign that recovery is impossible

Example: After a slip, you say "I've already ruined it" and act out repeatedly for days or weeks, abandoning all your coping strategies.

How to respond:

- Recognize you're in a relapse, not just a lapse
- Reach out for help immediately (therapist, support group, accountability partner)
- Recommit to your recovery plan
- Identify what led to the relapse and adjust your plan

THE CRITICAL DIFFERENCE:

LAPSE: One mistake → Learn from it → Get back on track

RELAPSE: One mistake → "I've ruined everything" → Continue acting out → Full return to old patterns

What determines whether a lapse becomes a relapse?

Your response.

If you treat a lapse as evidence that you're worthless and give up, it becomes a relapse. If you treat it as a mistake to learn from and recommit immediately, it stays a lapse.

The Relapse Process

Relapse is not a sudden event. It's a process that unfolds over time, often beginning days or weeks before any sexual behavior occurs.

Understanding the relapse process helps you intervene early.

THE RELAPSE PROCESS:

STAGE 1: LIFESTYLE IMBALANCE

Your life gets out of balance. Recovery practices slip.

What it looks like:

- Skipping meetings or therapy
- Not using your coping toolkit
- Neglecting self-care (sleep, exercise, nutrition)
- Overworking or over-committing
- Isolating from support

Early warning: "I'm too busy for recovery work right now."

STAGE 2: TRIGGER OCCURS

An internal or external trigger activates the cycle.

Common triggers:

- HALT states (Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired)
- Relationship conflict
- Work stress or financial pressure
- Boredom or free time
- Exposure to sexual cues

Early warning: "This is too much to handle right now."

STAGE 3: CRAVING EMERGES

The urge to act out appears. Your brain starts seeking escape.

What it looks like:

- Intrusive thoughts about sexual behavior
- Increasing preoccupation
- Fantasizing about acting out

- Feeling restless or agitated

Early warning: "Maybe just this once wouldn't hurt."

STAGE 4: PERMISSION-GIVING THOUGHTS

Your mind generates justifications for acting out.

Common thoughts:

- "I deserve this after the week I've had"
- "Just this once won't matter"
- "I've already failed, might as well continue"
- "No one will know"
- "I'll start fresh tomorrow"

Early warning: You're actively trying to convince yourself it's okay.

STAGE 5: HIGH-RISK SITUATION

You put yourself in a situation where acting out is likely.

What it looks like:

- Going to locations associated with acting out
- Opening incognito browser
- Creating opportunity (ensuring you're alone)
- Engaging in rituals
- Deliberately ignoring warning signs

Early warning: "I'm just checking, I won't actually do anything."

STAGE 6: LAPSE

You engage in the sexual behavior.

What happens:

- Temporary relief or pleasure

- Reality crashes back in
- Shame and guilt emerge
- Fear of consequences

Critical moment: What you do next determines if this becomes a relapse.

STAGE 7: ABSTINENCE VIOLATION EFFECT (AVE)

This is the make-or-break moment.

Path 1 (Lapse stays a lapse):

- "I made a mistake, but I can stop right now"
- Stop the behavior immediately
- Use coping strategies
- Reach out for support
- Learn from what happened

Path 2 (Lapse becomes relapse):

- "I've already ruined everything"
- All-or-nothing thinking takes over
- Continue acting out
- Abandon recovery efforts
- Full return to old patterns

EXERCISE 1: UNDERSTANDING MY RELAPSE PROCESS

Think about a past lapse or relapse. Map out what happened at each stage:

Stage 1 - Lifestyle Imbalance: What got out of balance before the lapse?

Stage 2 - Trigger: What triggered the urge?

Stage 3 - Craving: What did the craving feel like?

Stage 4 - Permission-Giving Thoughts: What did I tell myself to justify it?

Stage 5 - High-Risk Situation: What situation did I put myself in?

Stage 6 - Lapse: What behavior did I engage in?

Stage 7 - What Happened Next: Did it stay a lapse or become a relapse? Why?

Early Warning Signs

Every man has personal early warning signs—subtle changes in thinking, emotions, or behavior that indicate he's heading toward a lapse.

Recognizing these signs early gives you time to intervene.

CATEGORIES OF WARNING SIGNS:

CHANGES IN THINKING:

- Increased preoccupation with sex
- Fantasizing about acting out
- Minimizing the consequences
- Justifying or rationalizing behavior
- All-or-nothing thinking
- "I'm cured" or "I've got this handled" (complacency)

CHANGES IN EMOTIONS:

- Increased irritability or anger

- Feeling overwhelmed or hopeless
- Emotional numbness
- Increased anxiety or restlessness
- Boredom or disconnection

CHANGES IN BEHAVIOR:

- Skipping therapy or group meetings
- Avoiding accountability partner
- Isolating from others
- Not using coping strategies
- Testing boundaries ("just looking")
- Neglecting self-care
- Overworking or staying overly busy

RELATIONSHIP SIGNS:

- Increased conflict with partner
- Withdrawal from partner or friends
- Lying or keeping secrets (even small ones)
- Avoiding intimacy

LIFESTYLE SIGNS:

- HALT states (Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired)
- Poor sleep
- Skipped meals or poor nutrition
- No exercise
- Too much free time or boredom
- High stress with no outlet

EXERCISE 2: MY PERSONAL WARNING SIGNS INVENTORY

Review the categories above. Identify YOUR specific warning signs.

Check all that apply, and add your own:

THINKING CHANGES:

- ☐ Increased sexual preoccupation
- ☐ Fantasizing about acting out
- ☐ Minimizing consequences
- ☐ "I deserve this" thinking
- ☐ "I'm cured" complacency
- ☐ Other: _____

EMOTIONAL CHANGES:

- ☐ Irritability or anger
- ☐ Feeling overwhelmed
- ☐ Numbness
- ☐ Anxiety or restlessness
- ☐ Boredom
- ☐ Other: _____

BEHAVIORAL CHANGES:

- ☐ Skipping meetings or therapy
- ☐ Avoiding accountability
- ☐ Isolating from others
- ☐ Not using coping strategies
- ☐ Testing boundaries
- ☐ Neglecting self-care
- ☐ Other: _____

RELATIONSHIP CHANGES:

- ☐ Conflict with partner
- ☐ Withdrawal from others
- ☐ Lying or secrets
- ☐ Avoiding intimacy
- ☐ Other: _____

LIFESTYLE CHANGES:

- ☐ Hungry (skipped meals)
- ☐ Angry (unresolved conflict)
- ☐ Lonely (isolated)

- [ ] Tired (poor sleep)
- [ ] High stress
- [ ] Too much free time
- [ ] Other: _____

MY TOP 5 PERSONAL WARNING SIGNS:

Based on the checklist above, identify your five most reliable early warning signs:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

The Traffic Light System

This is a simple visual system for assessing your relapse risk at any given moment.

🟢 GREEN: STABLE RECOVERY

What it looks like:

- Using recovery tools consistently
- Attending therapy/meetings regularly
- Connected to support system
- Managing stress effectively
- Urges are manageable
- Feeling hopeful and engaged

What to do:

- Keep doing what you're doing
- Don't get complacent
- Continue all recovery practices

🟡 YELLOW: WARNING SIGNS PRESENT

What it looks like:

- Some warning signs appearing
- Increased urges or preoccupation
- Slipping on recovery practices
- Increased stress or conflict
- Feeling overwhelmed
- Starting to isolate

What to do:

- **STOP AND ASSESS:** Which warning signs are present?
- **INCREASE SUPPORT:** Call accountability partner, attend extra meeting, schedule therapy
- **USE COPING STRATEGIES:** Return to basics
- **ADDRESS HALT STATES:** Eat, rest, connect, resolve conflict
- **BE HONEST:** Talk to someone about what you're experiencing

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🔴 RED: HIGH RISK OF LAPSE

What it looks like:

- Multiple warning signs present
- Strong, persistent urges
- Already engaging in rituals
- Permission-giving thoughts active
- In a high-risk situation
- Feeling like acting out is inevitable

What to do:

- **EMERGENCY MODE:** This is a crisis
- **REACH OUT IMMEDIATELY:** Call therapist, accountability partner, crisis line

- **REMOVE YOURSELF:** Leave the situation physically
- **USE ALL COPING STRATEGIES:** Don't rely on willpower alone
- **BE RADICALLY HONEST:** Tell someone exactly where you are
- **COMMIT TO 24 HOURS:** Just get through today without acting out

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EXERCISE 3: MY TRAFFIC LIGHT ASSESSMENT

Where am I right now?

Current status: 🟢 Green | 🟡 Yellow | 🔴 Red (circle one)

Why do I assess myself at this level?

_____

_____

_____

If YELLOW or RED, what specific warning signs are present?

_____

_____

_____

What action do I need to take right now?

_____

_____

_____

Who can I reach out to for support?

_____

_____

Phase 1 Review: What I've Learned

You've completed **Phase 1: Foundation & Stabilization**. Take time to reflect on what you've learned over the past 8 weeks.

PHASE 1 TOPICS:

Week 1: Understanding CSBD, the addiction cycle, shame vs. guilt

Week 2: Personal cycle mapping, triggers, Pause and Observe

Week 3: Cognitive distortions, thought records, the 3 C's

Week 4: Urge surfing, coping toolkit, managing impulses

Week 5: Shame vs. guilt, self-compassion, accountability

Week 6: Attachment styles, intimacy vs. intensity, relationships

Week 7: Problem-solving, assertive communication, boundaries

Week 8: Lapse vs. relapse, warning signs, traffic light system

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EXERCISE 4: PHASE 1 REFLECTION

What has been most helpful so far?

What skill or concept has had the biggest impact on my recovery?

What has been most difficult?

What do I still struggle with?

How have I grown in the past 8 weeks?

What patterns have I noticed about myself?

What am I most proud of?

What do I need to continue working on in Phase 2?

Celebrating Progress

Recovery is hard work. You've completed 8 weeks of intensive self-examination and skill-building.

Take a moment to acknowledge what you've accomplished:

- You've shown up consistently for 8 weeks
- You've faced uncomfortable truths about yourself
- You've practiced new skills even when it felt awkward
- You've tracked your patterns daily
- You've done the hard work of self-reflection
- You've challenged shame and practiced self-compassion
- You've learned to recognize your cycle and triggers
- You've built a coping toolkit
- You're developing awareness and skills for long-term recovery

That's significant. That matters. You should be proud.

Preparing for Phase 2

Phase 2 (Weeks 9-16) shifts from **behavioral management** to **values-based living**.

What's coming:

Weeks 9-10: Introduction to ACT (Acceptance and Commitment Therapy) and cognitive defusion

Weeks 11-12: Values clarification and mindfulness practices

Weeks 13-14: Committed action and identity beyond CSBD

Weeks 15-16: Comprehensive relapse prevention and integration

The focus shifts from:

- "How do I stop this behavior?"
- TO "What kind of life do I want to build?"

Phase 1 gave you the tools to manage urges and interrupt the cycle.

Phase 2 will help you build a life worth living—a life that doesn't require escape.

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 8

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add focus on warning signs.

Additional tracking:

- What warning signs appeared this week?
- What's my traffic light status each day?
- Did I intervene early when warning signs appeared?

[7 daily logs with same format as previous weeks—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 8 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 9, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 8 material
- [ ] Understand the difference between lapse and relapse
- [ ] Map out a past lapse/relapse using the 7-stage process
- [ ] Complete personal warning signs inventory
- [ ] Identify my top 5 warning signs
- [ ] Assess my current traffic light status
- [ ] Complete Phase 1 reflection
- [ ] Write: "What I've learned in Phase 1"
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days
- [ ] Celebrate progress and prepare mentally for Phase 2

Notes for Week 8:

CONGRATULATIONS

You've completed **PHASE 1: FOUNDATION & STABILIZATION**.

You've built the foundation. You've learned the basics of managing urges, challenging distorted thoughts, practicing self-compassion, and communicating assertively.

Now it's time to build the life.

Phase 2 begins next week.

END OF WEEK 8 | END OF PHASE 1